Literal Chaos

Expert | Mixed expressions | Student practice

Name: _____ Date: _____

1. Add fuel to the fire

The group was already upset about the rumour. Repeating it as a joke only added fuel to the fire.

A. Make an existing problem worse

B. Solve a problem before it begins

C. Help everyone calm down

My context clue: _____

2. The tip of the iceberg

We found one broken link on the website. The audit revealed fifty more problems, so that first link was only the tip of the iceberg.

A. A small visible part of a much larger issue

B. The final problem that has already been solved

C. The most useful idea in a discussion

My context clue: _____

3. Once in a blue moon

My cousin lives far away, and we have met only twice in five years. We see each other once in a blue moon.

A. Very rarely

B. At a predictable time each week

C. Every evening

My context clue: _____

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4. On thin ice

After ignoring two reminders about the equipment, Max was on thin ice. One more unsafe choice would mean sitting out.

A. Completely safe from consequences

B. At risk of getting into more trouble

C. Unable to decide between two good choices

My context clue: _____

5. The memory drifted away like a feather.

At breakfast I could recall only one tiny part of the dream. The memory drifted away like a feather until even that part was gone.

A. The memory returned in exact detail

B. The memory gradually became difficult to hold onto

C. The memory became heavier over time

My context clue: _____

6. The rumour spread like fire through dry grass.

One person whispered the rumour before lunch. By the next break, nearly every class had heard it. It spread like fire through dry grass.

A. The rumour travelled quickly from person to person

B. The rumour made everyone feel warm

C. The rumour disappeared without reaching anyone

My context clue: _____

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7. His words were ice.

"You are not part of our team," he said, turning away without a smile. His words were ice.

A. His words felt cold and unfriendly

B. His words helped everyone feel welcome

C. His words were difficult to hear because he spoke softly

My context clue: _____

8. Her heart was a locked door.

Whenever we asked how she felt about moving, she changed the subject. Her heart was a locked door.

A. She had lost the key to her house

B. She welcomed every question about her feelings

C. She kept her feelings private and hard to reach

My context clue: _____

9. I cried a river.

At the end of the film, I cried a river. In reality, I used three tissues, but the goodbye scene felt terribly sad.

A. I cried a great deal

B. My tears formed a real river

C. I was too cheerful to cry

My context clue: _____

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10. The shelves reached the moon.

From where the little child stood, the library shelves reached the moon. An adult could reach the top shelf with a small step stool.

A. The shelves were easy to reach from the floor

B. The shelves seemed astonishingly tall

C. The shelves had been built in space

My context clue: _____

11. The moon kept watch over the village.

The last window went dark. Above the quiet roofs, the moon kept watch over the village until dawn.

A. The moon could see and protect every person

B. The moon prevented the sun from rising

C. The moon seemed like a calm, watchful presence

My context clue: _____

12. The key refused to turn.

I pushed the rusty key gently, then tried again. The key refused to turn, and the old cupboard stayed shut.

A. The key stayed stuck when someone tried to turn it

B. The key chose to disobey a spoken request

C. The key opened the lock immediately

My context clue: _____

Literal Chaos

Expert | Mixed expressions | TEACHER ANSWER KEY

Answers and explanations. Keep separate from student pages.

1. Make an existing problem worse

The group is already upset, and the joke worsens the situation. There is no actual fire in the scene.

2. A small visible part of a much larger issue

One visible problem leads to fifty more. The first discovery is a small part of a larger issue.

3. Very rarely

Meeting only twice in five years supports the meaning "very rarely." The phrase does not predict a date.

4. At risk of getting into more trouble

The warning about sitting out shows that Max is close to a consequence.

5. The memory gradually became difficult to hold onto

The dream becomes harder to remember and eventually disappears. A drifting feather suggests something slipping out of reach.

6. The rumour travelled quickly from person to person

A message reaches nearly every class quickly. The comparison emphasizes its rapid spread.

Literal Chaos

Expert | Mixed expressions | TEACHER ANSWER KEY

Answers and explanations. Keep separate from student pages.

7. His words felt cold and unfriendly

The rejection and turning away make the speech feel emotionally cold.

8. She kept her feelings private and hard to reach

Changing the subject prevents others from learning her feelings. A locked door represents that barrier.

9. I cried a great deal

Three tissues contrasts with a whole river. The exaggeration expresses how deeply sad the viewer felt.

10. The shelves seemed astonishingly tall

An adult needs only a small stool. The impossible height exaggerates how tall the shelves seem to the child.

11. The moon seemed like a calm, watchful presence

The moon remains above the sleeping village. "Kept watch" gives it the role of a human guard.

12. The key stayed stuck when someone tried to turn it

The rusty key stays stuck. "Refused" describes a mechanical problem as if the key could make a choice.